

Q I am gluten intolerant. What does this mean for my baby?

A **gluten-free diet can be low in calcium, iron, fiber, zinc, B-vitamins, vitamin D, and magnesium.** If you're celiac, it's important that you continue with your gluten-free diet, since studies show that pregnant celiac women who reintroduce gluten to their diet can be at increased risk of miscarriage and low birth weight. There are no specific dietary guidelines to follow other than eating a healthy balanced diet, but the fact that you are gluten-free means you could be lacking nutrients—specifically iron, vitamin B₁₂, and calcium. You may require some supplementation in addition to what you eat in order to meet the recommended daily amounts of these missing nutrients. Talk to your doctor, who will be able to assess your diet and give you individual advice. In the meantime, increase quantities of potatoes, rice, corn, nuts, beans and lentils, red meat, chicken, fish, eggs, and dairy in your daily diet, all of which will help boost your intake of those nutrients that are otherwise present in gluten-containing foods.

Q Should I start shopping for organic foods now that I'm pregnant?

We are exposed to chemical pesticides and fertilizers in all kinds of ways—in the air, in cleaning products, and in the food we eat.

Pesticides work by attacking the nervous systems of insects. Concern for unborn babies centers on the effects these chemicals may have on neural development, because studies have found tiny amounts of expressed sequence tags (ests) or DNA clones in amniotic fluid.

Although risks from food are smaller than those from airborne pollutants, anything you can do to minimize your exposure can only be a positive thing. If you aren't able to switch to an entirely organic diet, select wisely. For example, it's better to spend extra on organic meats as unorganic meats may have hormones and antibiotics within the flesh that are impossible to remove through cooking, than on organic fruits and vegetables, which you can wash and peel (in most hard fruits and vegetables, pesticides remain primarily on the outer skin and leaves). Do, though, choose organic soft fruits, which are less likely to have residues beneath the skin.

If you aren't able to switch to an entirely **organic** diet, select your organic purchases wisely and include **meat** and **soft fruit**.

Q I'm vegetarian. Can I continue eating as I usually do?

It is perfectly possible to remain vegetarian or vegan while pregnant and have a healthy baby, but be prepared to supplement any nutrients you may be lacking.

Make sure that you're aware of the nutrients your vegetarian or vegan diet does and doesn't give you, and discuss your diet with your doctor. If you need extra nutrients, he or she may advise you to take supplements for the duration of your pregnancy (especially

important for iron). For your own peace of mind, check first that any supplements are not animal derived. You may also need to plan your meals a little more carefully, but you should remain in good health throughout your pregnancy.

PREGNANCY REQUIREMENTS

Combining fresh foods with supplements is a good idea if you are vegetarian or vegan.



Balanced diet As a vegetarian or vegan, make sure you get all your major food groups: grains, protein, fruit and vegetables, dairy, and fats.

» **Iodine:** you may need to take supplements of iodine, which—among other things—is essential for maintaining pregnancy to term, a healthy birth, and improved brain function in your baby.

» **Vitamin B₁₂, essential fats, iron, and vitamin D:** these are all essential to take either through food or in a supplement form.

» **Essential amino acids:** daily quantities of beans, peas, or other legumes; corn or wheat products; grains; seeds; nuts; brewer's yeast and soy; cheese, milk, eggs or other dairy; and a broad color spectrum of vegetables should provide all the amino acids you need.

» **Iron:** if you don't need to supplement, good sources are leafy green vegetables (spinach and kale are good), fortified breakfast cereals, dried fruits, and whole-wheat bread. Drink orange juice at the same meal to help iron absorption from these foods.

» **Omega fats:** flaxseed, walnut oil, and soybeans are all good sources of omega-3 fats; nuts, grains, safflower, sesame, and sunflower oils are all good sources of omega-6.

» **Calcium:** if you're vegan, make sure you get enough calcium. Leafy green vegetables, sesame seeds (and derivatives such as tahini), and legumes are all sources. Look for calcium-fortified vegan products such as tofu, soy, rice, oats, and bread.